Badge Guidelines

The Trust Signal

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1. Purpose

These badges are a voluntary micro credentialing system for creators who want to signal their commitment to transparency, integrity, and accountability. By displaying a badge, you help audiences quickly recognize content that has been produced with ethical practices.

The three badges form a complete framework that covers:

Source integrity (Collected)

Intellectual honesty (Credited)

Process transparency (Curated)

Collected

I went to the source.

What it signals: The content is based on primary, first hand, or grassroots information.

Earning criteria: You must have conducted at least one of the following:

• Interviewed a local expert, eyewitness, or community member

• Gathered on the ground data (e.g., site visit, field research)

• Surveyed real communities (formal or informal)

• Used original documents or primary sources not widely available online

Example caption: "I visited three community farms and interviewed the owners to understand water conservation. #Collected"

Credited

I honor the original.

What it signals: All ideas, footage, images, and inspiration used in the content are properly attributed to their original creators.

Earning criteria: You must:

• Clearly attribute any third-party ideas, quotes, or research

• Credit footage, images, music, or other media (even if royalty free)

• Link to or name the original inspiration when your work builds on someone else's concept

• Avoid any form of plagiarism or uncredited reuse

Example caption: "Animation inspired by the work of @sciencestudio. All data from the IPCC 2024 report. #Credited"

Curated

I show how it was made.

What it signals: The production process is transparent, especially regarding editing, compilation, and the use of artificial intelligence.

Earning criteria: You must:

• Label any sections created with generative AI (text, image, video, voice)

• Disclose composite edits (e.g., "this is a compilation of three interviews")

• Explain your curation process if the content is assembled from multiple sources

Example caption: "This script was drafted with AI assistance. All visuals are original footage. Full disclosure in comments. #Curated"

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2. General Usage Rules

Honesty first: Only use a badge if you fully meet the criteria. Misuse undermines trust for everyone.

Be specific: Always include a short explanation of why you earned the badge (in caption, video text, or a dedicated “behind the scenes” post).

Badges are free: You cannot buy them; they are earned through transparent actions.

One badge per post: You can only display one badge that best fits the content if all criteria are met.

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3. Pledge & Accountability

When you first start using the badges, we ask you to sign the Creator Pledge (available on The website). By signing, you agree to:

Uphold the earning criteria for each badge you display.

Correct any mistakes publicly and adjust your badge use if needed.

Encourage your audience to ask questions about your process.

If a viewer questions whether a badge was rightfully earned, you should respond transparently. In cases of repeated misuse, your name may be removed from the public list of pledging creators.

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4. Questions & Support

For questions about badge eligibility, usage, or to report misuse, contact thetrustsignals@gmail.com

These guidelines are version 1.0 and may be updated as the ecosystem evolves. We welcome feedback from the creator community.

The Tree Must Appears – Let’s grow a healthier information environment, together.